The Acne-Safe Cheat Sheet

Every rating in this sheet comes from the AcneSafeCheck database of 559 ingredients, compiled from published comedogenicity references (Fulton et al. 1984; Draelos & DiNardo 2006; AAD). Scale: 0 = non-comedogenic (acne safe) … 5 = highly pore-clogging. 'FA' marks common fungal-acne (Malassezia) triggers. Version: September 2026.

1. Red flags — avoid in leave-on products (rated 4–5)

Ingredient	Rating	Category	FA
Algae Extract	5/5	Marine	
Carrageenan	5/5	Thickener	
Isocetyl Stearate	5/5	Ester	yes
Isopropyl Isostearate	5/5	Ester	yes
Isopropyl Linoleate	5/5	Ester	yes
Isopropyl Myristate	5/5	Ester	yes
Laureth-4	5/5	Emulsifier	yes
Myristyl Myristate	5/5	Ester	yes
Octyl Stearate	5/5	Ester	yes
Red Algae	5/5	Marine	
Sodium Lauryl Sulfate	5/5	Surfactant	
Wheat Germ Oil	5/5	Oil	yes
Acetylated Lanolin	4/5	Occlusive	
Acetylated Lanolin Alcohol	4/5	Occlusive	
Algin	4/5	Thickener	
Ceteareth-20	4/5	Emulsifier	yes
Cocoa Butter	4/5	Butter	yes
Coconut Butter	4/5	Butter	yes
Coconut Oil	4/5	Oil	yes
Isopropyl Palmitate	4/5	Ester	yes
Isostearyl Isostearate	4/5	Ester	yes
Isostearyl Neopentanoate	4/5	Ester	yes
Laminaria Digitata Extract	4/5	Marine	
Lauric Acid	4/5	Fatty acid	yes
Lecithin	4/5	Emulsifier	yes
Linseed / Flaxseed Oil	4/5	Oil	yes
Myristyl Lactate	4/5	Ester	yes
Octyl Palmitate	4/5	Ester	yes
PEG-16 Lanolin	4/5	Emulsifier	
Polyglyceryl-3 Diisostearate	4/5	Emulsifier	yes
Steareth-10	4/5	Emulsifier	yes

Higher on the ingredient list = higher concentration = bigger risk.

2. Watch-list — moderate risk (rated 3)

Ingredient	Category	FA
Avocado Oil	Oil	yes
Butyl Stearate	Ester	yes
Cetyl Acetate	Ester	yes
Coconut Alkanes	Oil	
Corn Oil	Oil	yes
Cotton Seed Oil	Oil	yes
D&C Red 17	Colorant	
D&C Red 21	Colorant	
D&C Red 30	Colorant	
D&C Red 36	Colorant	
D&C Red 6	Colorant	
D&C Red 7	Colorant	
D&C Red 9	Colorant	
Decyl Oleate	Ester	yes
Glyceryl Stearate SE	Ester	yes
Laureth-23	Emulsifier	yes
Mink Oil	Oil	yes
Myristic Acid	Fatty acid	yes
PEG-8 Stearate	Emulsifier	yes
PPG-2 Myristyl Ether Propionate	Ester	yes
Sesame Oil	Oil	yes
Shark Liver Oil	Oil	yes
Sodium Laureth Sulfate	Surfactant	yes
Sorbitan Oleate	Emulsifier	yes
Sorbitan Sesquioleate	Emulsifier	yes
Soybean Oil	Oil	yes
Spearmint Oil	Essential oil	
Wheat Germ Glyceride	Oil	yes

3. Safe swaps by category (rated 0–1)

Oil: Argan Oil (0/5, FA) · Hemp Seed Oil (0/5, FA) · Safflower Oil (0/5, FA) · Sunflower Oil (0/5, FA)

Butter: Mango Butter (0/5, FA) · Shea Butter (0/5, FA) · Cupuacu Butter (1/5, FA) · Kokum Butter (1/5, FA)

Ester: Caprylic/Capric Triglyceride (1/5) · Isohexadecane (1/5) · Cetearyl Ethylhexanoate (1/5, FA) · Coco-Caprylate (1/5, FA)

Emulsifier: Cetearyl Glucoside (0/5) · Polysorbate 20 (0/5, FA) · Hydrogenated Lecithin (1/5, FA) · PEG-100 Stearate (1/5, FA)

Humectant: Betaine (0/5) · Butylene Glycol (0/5) · Glycereth-26 (0/5) · Glycerin (0/5)

Silicone: Cyclohexasiloxane (0/5) · Cyclomethicone (0/5) · Cyclopentasiloxane (0/5) · Amodimethicone (1/5)

4. Fungal acne? Start with these (rated 0–1, no Malassezia triggers)

Acai Extract, Acetyl Glucosamine, Acetyl Hexapeptide-8, Acrylates/C10-30 Alkyl Acrylate Crosspolymer, Adansonia Digitata Extract, Adapalene, Adenosine, Agar, Alcohol Denat., Allantoin, Allantoin Extract, Allium Cepa Extract, Aloe Barbadensis Leaf Juice, Aloe Extract, Aloe Ferox Leaf Extract, Aloe Juice Powder, Aloe Powder, Aloe Vera, Alpha Lipoic Acid, Alpha-Arbutin, Aluminum Starch Octenylsuccinate, Aminomethyl Propanol, Amla Extract, Ammonium Lactate, Anisic Acid, Apple Extract, Apricot Extract, Arbutin, Argireline, Arnica Extract, Arnica Montana Flower Extract, Artemisia Vulgaris Extract, Artichoke Leaf Extract, Ascorbic Acid, Ascorbyl Glucoside, Ashwagandha Extract, Asiaticoside, Asparagus Extract, Avena Sativa Kernel Extract, Avobenzone.

5. How to read any label in 30 seconds

1. Scan the first 5–7 ingredients — that's where the concentration is.
2. Match them against section 1. One red flag near the top is usually enough to skip the product.
3. "Non-comedogenic" on the front label is unregulated — always check the actual INCI list.
4. A single ingredient's score isn't a verdict on a finished formula — treat it as a risk signal and patch test new products (Draelos & DiNardo, 2006).
5. Small, itchy, uniform bumps? Run the fungal-acne check, not just the comedogenic one.

Check any product in seconds: **acnesafecheck.com** — paste the list or scan a photo. Full database, comparisons and API: acnesafecheck.com/data.html. Informational only, not medical advice. © AcneSafeCheck, CC BY 4.0 with attribution.